

## Maria Silva

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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Criminal Paralegal role advertised through Reed. I am drawn to this position because of the firm's reputation for a genuinely people-centred environment and the hands-on exposure it offers within a busy Criminal Defence team — both of which align directly with where I am in my legal career.

My background spans litigation-adjacent work at Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner, front-line client advising at Citizens Advice East Berkshire, and academic grounding in dispute resolution at Queen Mary. Across these roles I have built practical skills that transfer directly to criminal defence work: taking detailed factual statements from clients in sensitive circumstances, identifying evidential gaps, drafting procedural documents under deadline pressure, and managing case files with care and precision.

At BCLP, I supported a complex international arbitration through to a significant procedural deadline, reviewing and organising evidence, drafting procedural orders and sections of the Claimant's memorial, and coordinating documents across the team. At the same firm's Real Estate Disputes seat, I prepared electronic hearing bundles, assisted with skeleton arguments, and managed court filings across several concurrent matters. A partner and associate noted that my performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor.

At Citizens Advice, I interview clients across a range of legally and emotionally complex matters — including housing, debt and employment — take detailed chronological statements, identify the key legal and evidential issues, and translate procedural requirements into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable individuals. This is work that demands both rigour and genuine client focus, qualities I would bring to supporting a Criminal Defence team.

I am based in the Reading area, available immediately, and looking for exactly the kind of fast-paced, progression-focused environment this role describes. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my experience could support the team.

Yours sincerely,  
Maria Fernanda Silva